UNCOMMON SCHOOLS

CHANGE HISTORY

Uncommon Schools Brand Voice

For the website copywriter
November 2026

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30 YEARS OF IMPACT

Who Uncommon is

A nonprofit network of 53 charter schools and more than 21,000 students in Boston, Camden, Newark, New York City and Rochester. Its mission is for every student to graduate from college and achieve their dreams.

THE STORY UNCOMMON TELLS ABOUT ITSELF

It began with 72 scholars. In 1997 Norman Atkins and Jamey Verrilli founded North Star Academy on a single floor of fifth grade classrooms in Newark, New Jersey.

One belief, held since then. Every child, regardless of zip code, deserves an outstanding education and the opportunity to attend college and graduate.

Joyful and rigorous. Uncommon describes its schools as joyful and rigorous, full of love and learning, and fiercely dedicated to changing history by closing the opportunity gap.

Who the students are. Ninety five percent identify as Black or Latino and 86 percent are economically disadvantaged. Most graduates are the first in their families to attend college.

53
schools

21,000+
students each year

8,011
high school graduates

4x
the college graduation rate of their peers

91%
family satisfaction

162
alumni now working at Uncommon

Behind every number is a student, a family, a teacher, and a budding future.

The 30 Years of Impact page

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Who we write for first: families

Parents of pre-K to 12 students looking for a top performing, free school for their child. They are the site's largest audience, most of them are new to Uncommon, and three in four of them are on a phone.

WHAT FAMILIES DECIDE ON

A neighbor's word. Word of mouth and other parents are the strongest reason families give, whatever channel brought them to the site.

Safety, then the day to day. Location, hours, transportation, before and after care, what the building looks and feels like, and skilled teachers.

Young children. Most applications are for kindergarten through grade 8, and most of those for kindergarten through grade 2. College is the long game, not the pitch to the parent of a five year old.

Answers, fast. Transportation, special education, sports, extracurriculars and uniforms, found in a click or two.

HOW TO WRITE TO THEM

From a position of strength. Say why Uncommon is a winning team. Never say why another school is not.

Why parents love the school, not what the network is proud of. Awards and prizes are not what a family decides on.

Stories that match the application. The elementary classroom, drop off and pick up, a clean building, a teacher who knows the child.

English and Spanish. Enrollment pieces run in both languages: Enroll today. ¡Inscríbase hoy!

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Who we write for second: candidates

Certified teachers first, then early career talent, career changers, and business professionals for the home office. They compare Uncommon with every other employer they could choose.

WHAT CANDIDATES ASK

What do you pay, what are the benefits, can I move up. The three questions candidates ask before anything else.

What is a charter school. The difference between a charter school and a district school, answered up front, not buried in a FAQ.

I could teach anywhere. Why Uncommon? Answered with people as much as text: teachers and leaders in their own words.

What will my day look like. The classroom, the prep period, the coaching. A day in the life is what makes someone open the job description.

HOW TO WRITE TO THEM

Teach or lead, then region. The journey starts with the kind of work, not the city.

Say what the hiring process is. The steps, how long they take, and what happens at each one.

Facts from Benefits at a Glance. The home office version lists nineteen days of paid time off, paid winter and summer breaks, twelve weeks at full pay for birthing parents and a 403(b) with employer match. There is a version for each region; use the one that matches the page.

Uncommon's own answer to why. Accelerate your growth with a proven approach to professional development. Drive results that truly matter to students' lives. Be part of a joyful, supportive community of colleagues invested in each other's success.

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Who we write for third: donors

Prospective donors and partners. Today the site works for people who already know Uncommon and gives a newcomer no reason to give.

WHAT THE DEVELOPMENT TEAM HEARS

Four questions the donate page does not answer. Why Uncommon? Why now? Why philanthropy? Why me? It explains impact and stops there.

Giving is social. Donors want to feel they are joining a prestigious and impactful community. Today there are no testimonials from board members or foundations.

We are not bragging enough. The results that do not move a parent are exactly what moves a donor.

HOW TO WRITE TO THEM

Emotion and impact. Content that evokes emotion and shows the true impact of the mission.

A case for support. The areas of need, what a gift does, and gift impact a donor can download and share.

Proof with a face. The network's numbers paired with a student, a family or an alumnus, the way the 30 Years of Impact page does it.

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How Uncommon sounds

Five qualities. Each one is taken from how Uncommon already writes about itself or from what its own people asked for.

Joyful and rigorous	Our schools are joyful and rigorous, full of love and learning. Uncommon's own words, and the same standard it sets for its photography: joyful and authentic, honest and unpretentious, the more candid the better.
From a position of strength	Everyone wants to join a winning team. Uncommon says what it does well and never runs down another school. In its own words: for 30 years, Uncommon students have shown what is possible when excellence and opportunity meet.
A person behind every number	Behind every number is a student, a family, a teacher, and a budding future. Results land when the reader can see who they belong to: students who are known, challenged, and supported every step of the way.
Collegiate, not corporate	Staff say the current site feels more corporate than collegiate and misses the emotional connection and school identity. The new copy sounds like a school full of children, not a company.
Concrete and short	Staff call the current content repetitive and overly verbose. Say the specific thing once. Headlines of six words or fewer may run in capitals; anything longer runs in sentence case.

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Words we use and words we avoid

Only the terms the sources settle. Where Uncommon has a word for something, use it.

USE

Charter school network. Uncommon Schools is a network of charter schools, free and open to all. Never public school on its own.

Uncommon Schools, then Uncommon. The full name first, Uncommon after that.

Scholars and students. Both appear in Uncommon's own writing. Scholars is the word it reaches for when it speaks with pride, as in 72 founding scholars.

Regions by city. Boston, Camden, Newark, New York City and Rochester. Schools by their current names: Roxbury Prep in Boston, North Star Academy in Newark, Camden Prep, Rochester Prep, and the Uncommon schools of New York City.

Both languages for enrollment. Enroll today sits beside ¡Inscríbase hoy!

AVOID

Public school on its own. It erases what makes Uncommon different, and the difference is the first thing candidates ask about.

Old school names. Staff still find pages that call a Newark campus Elementary School 7 and search results that land on retired New York City names.

Internal shorthand. EVP, DOO, HSST and the like mean something inside Uncommon and nothing outside it.

Dated proof. Results from the Class of 2016 and an award a decade old undermine the credibility they were meant to build.

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What the current site gets wrong

Thirty six staff across the network reviewed the site in May 2026. These are the faults they named, in their words, and what they asked for instead.

On the current site	What they asked for instead
Outdated content everywhere: photos of staff who have left, wrong school names, results from the Class of 2016 and 2019.	Facts the team can keep current, so that nothing lives on the site longer than it should.
Feels more corporate than collegiate. Dark, and missing the energy of the schools it represents.	Joy and school identity on the page, in words as well as photographs.
Careers organized by internal function, hard to find, and unchanged since 2018.	Organized by the candidate's question: do you want to teach, or to lead? Pay, benefits and growth in plain sight.
Videos and stories about college, while most applicants are five to ten years old.	Stories that connect to the majority of applications: elementary classrooms, safety, the school day.
Content that is repetitive and overly verbose, and a site that treats every visitor the same.	One message per section, written for the person reading it: family, candidate or donor.
A donate page that is generic and transactional.	Why Uncommon, why now, why philanthropy, why me, answered with impact and the people who already give.

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How each department speaks

Sixteen newsletters go out across Uncommon. Each shows what a department cares about and how it talks to its readers. Examples from Mailchimp follow once they are pulled.

Newsletter	Department
Uncommon Sense: Best Practices Instructional Blog	Media and Marketing
Marketing Quarterly Newsletter	Media
Co-CEO Monthly Staff Newsletter	Marketing
CEO Quarterly Update	Development
Senior Leadership Portfolio Quarterly Update	Development
Rochester Quarterly Newsletters	Rochester
HSST Quarterly Updates	HSST
Monthly Student Support Services Memos	Student Support Services
Monthly Alumni Digest	Alumni Success
Weekly College Completion Update	College Access and Success
External Affairs Newsblast	External team
Weekly Development Newsblast	Development
Juliana Worrell's Note	Elementary and middle schools
HS Weekly Update	High schools
DOO Weekly	CRO
Regional Family Newsletter	Media and External Affairs

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Sources

Everything in this document comes from these eight places. Read them in this order.

30 Years of Impact	https://uncommonschools.org/30th-anniversary/ Uncommon's story, numbers and voice as it writes them today.
Website Redesign Brief, June 2026	https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DZPaUetBq3nUL6AJ3RIjRaWPcaBYROcp16N3sBVU-3E/edit
Stakeholder Survey Summary Report, May 2026	https://docs.google.com/document/d/1gdBY4Sodz_4r5Jr--RiNXyE4eW6t1kbXglxhiRD0V6I/edit
Enrollment and recruitment team interviews, 2026	https://docs.google.com/document/d/1dRt_DJZGbjrRiqQSsDcRYoEJ_8r4cOXKz9YIYJnC17s/edit
Design Guidelines, June 2024	https://drive.google.com/file/d/1GTeEIh7EJB4xT0M36TVYnFRGS_Cdzggo/view
Benefits at a Glance, five versions	https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1TE5ARlkpyExw3F8qEDZWdF_5gzOFI0-u
Content Inventory Matrix	https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/16SNhrRgH-tizjs79ddF0PHRP3s9zUhgYanbunpWg6Yo/edit Every page of the new site, with its address and template.
Internal Comms Audit 2026	https://drive.google.com/file/d/1UnNxM1vuEJIYBBU7ZIG-9EbEwA26rVEh/view

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